

Consultation Response Notes: Meeting of 18 May 2026

ROH follow-up letter of 20 May 2026

Prepared for: Christa Dawson

ROH consultation follow-up letter of 20 May 2026 (meeting of 18 May). Highlighted passages are disputed or lacked practical clarity at consultation; notes set out Christa's position on timing, what remained open, and suitability assessment.

ROYAL BALLET & OPERA
PRIVATE AND CONFIDENTIAL
Christa Dawson
E&F Management and Business Services
20th May 2026

Dear Christa,

Consultation Meeting Follow Up

Following your meeting with Heather Walker and Steven Foulston on 18th May 2026, you were accompanied by Pamela Tan. Please find below summary of the key points that were raised or discussed.

Thank you for attending your recent consultation meeting regarding the proposed changes to the Business Support and Help Desk functions.

As discussed, we are proposing to merge these functions into a single, integrated team. The new structure would be led by an E&F Support Manager and supported by three E&F Support Officers. This team would be multi-functional, providing a comprehensive and collaborative support service across the department.

Note: Combining support, helpdesk, and operational tasks in one role may increase workload rather than streamline it. The proposed Officer JD is more helpdesk-focused than coordinator duties. Whether Christa could manage that in practice was not clarified at consultation.

Following a review of the proposed E&F Support Officer role, we are satisfied that your current role is sufficiently similar. Therefore, should the proposal proceed, you would be matched to one of the three E&F Support Officer positions.

Note: The restructure changes how the role works day to day. It should not be treated as an automatic direct match without a fuller assessment. The job description comparison shows different reporting, sign-off, and duties. See Job Description Comparison.

Note: At consultation ROH sought agreement on suitability before workload split, helpdesk hours, and office attendance were defined. Matching should follow assessment of how the role would work in practice, not a conclusion reached while key terms were still TBC.

You asked us why you were at risk. We explained that the aim was to streamline the current process, to remove duplication of effort between the business and help desk teams, to bring team together to work across the piece.

Note: Christa remains concerned the combined role may not be sustainable if support, helpdesk, and operational tasks sit together. Her concern is workload and clarity, not opposition to integrating teams.

You raised a concern that you did not feel that the E&F Support Officer role was a match to your skills and career aims, and represented a step back. We explained that the matching process was based on a comparison of job descriptions, and how the new role is an amalgamation of the responsibilities of the current 3 roles. We have not matched the roles based on personal attributes or career plans. We hope that all those matched to the jobs will see the new role as opportunity to broaden their skills and experience.

Note: Christa remains concerned how sign-off, authority, and day-to-day expectations would change under the proposed structure. She recognises overlap in some tasks. The concern is accountability and how duties would be carried out in the integrated team.

Note: Overlap in tasks on paper does not show the roles are the same in practice. Amalgamation on paper does not restore coordinator duties removed in the Officer JD (e.g. register management, project oversight, full budget monitoring).

Note: Part-time working, hybrid working, and childcare remain relevant to whether the alternative role is suitable. ROH limit the match to JD text. Practical implementation and flexible working still need objective assessment.

Note: The proposed JD emphasises helpdesk, reactive support, and administrative processing. Christa is willing to take on new tasks where defined. She remains concerned the coordinator remit is not preserved in the Officer JD.

You also explained that in your current role you have taken ownership of specific projects, for example access controls. We explained how the operational details of how the work would be shared out among the team would be discussed once the Manager was in place.

Note: Workload split and project ownership were deferred until mid to late June. Christa was asked to assess suitability before these arrangements could be clarified, including before the voluntary redundancy deadline.

You confirmed that you currently work 4 days pw, 2 in the office and 2 at home. You asked if this would continue? We explained that, though you could continue working 4 days pw, the new manager would need to discuss with you how much time would need to be spent in the office.

Note: Office attendance expectations remain TBC and were deferred to the new manager. At first flexible working was said to stay unchanged. Later, office time is for the new manager to decide. That was unclear before the VR deadline.

You asked how the work would be divided up across the team. We explained that though this would be discussed once the new manager was in post, we did not expect to do things exactly the same. We explained how we wanted to look at working more efficiently, utilising the mix of skills across the team to ensure cover for sickness/holidays and dealing with differing priorities as they arose.

Note: Workload split and cover arrangements were to be discussed once the manager was in post. There was no clarity on sickness cover, part-time cover, or working outside contracted days before Christa had to decide on VR.

You asked whether you would need to support the helpdesk, which is open from 8am to 6pm. We explained that this would need to be discussed with the new Manager.

Note: Helpdesk cover between 8am and 6pm remains TBC for part-time staff. Christa asked specifically. ROH said it must be discussed with the new Manager. This remained open past the VR deadline.

Note: Christa cannot assess helpdesk expectations before the manager is in post. Same timing issue as office attendance and workload split. Decisions were deferred past the voluntary redundancy application deadline.

You asked who decided on this proposal? We explained that the proposal had been developed jointly by Max, Heather and HR.

Note: Christa continues to engage in consultation and seek further written information. Useful context on who designed the proposal. It does not answer open questions on day-to-day operation, flexibility, or workload.

You asked about how much of the work would be desk based? We reassured you that the role would be both desk based and require time in the office, dealing with people and getting around the building.

Finally, you raised a concern that you did not feel the role was a suitable match for you, as it was a more junior role and did not offer you the same level of flexibility to your personal circumstances. You asked if you could take Voluntary Redundancy. We explained that you were eligible to apply for VR, but that we would only be able to consider your request if we had someone else at risk who was able to take on this role. We advised you to carefully consider the options before taking a decision to apply for VR.

Note: Flexible working is essential to assess suitability. Messages on office vs home working have been inconsistent. Christa remains concerned she lacks enough practical detail to assess whether the role would work for her part-time hybrid arrangement.

Note: Christa applied for VR to protect her position while questions remain unanswered, not to refuse consultation. She remains willing to engage. She applied for VR because key practical terms were still undefined before the deadline.

Best Wishes,

Isabella Makulova

HR Transformation Co-Ordinator

Position on direct match and suitable alternative employment

Christa's position on direct match and suitability (ACAS-aligned)

Christa recognises that some elements of her current role overlap with the proposed role, particularly administrative and coordination tasks. Her concern is not that there is no overlap, but that the proposed structure changes reporting lines, who signs off work, and practical expectations attached to those functions.

Meaningful consultation and ability to assess suitability

To assess whether a proposed role is suitable, Christa needs enough practical information about how it would work day to day, not only how duties are described in a job description.

At the 18 May consultation meeting, several important practical points remained undefined. The ROH follow-up letter of 20 May 2026 records that workload allocation, how work would be shared across the team, helpdesk coverage between 8am and 6pm, expectations for part-time staff, and wider team arrangements would be discussed once the new manager is in post (expected mid to late June). Although Christa works four days per week, how much office attendance would be required was similarly left for the new manager to discuss.

Christa was asked to assess suitability and make decisions about her employment, including whether to apply for voluntary redundancy, before these terms could be clarified. The voluntary redundancy deadline passed while workload split, helpdesk expectations, office attendance, and how shared work would be allocated remained unconfirmed.

Christa's concern is not resistance to change. She has continued to engage constructively in consultation. The concern is that she could not assess how the role would operate day to day before being asked to treat it as a predetermined direct match, and before key employment decisions were required.

The restructure is wide-ranging. The role should not be treated as an automatic direct match without fuller assessment. While there may be some overlap in duties, the proposed role appears to change the scope, structure, expectations, and practical operation of Christa's role. On that basis, it should be treated as proposed suitable alternative employment requiring a proper suitability assessment.

Moving operational expectations

- The proposed E&F Support Officer role shifts emphasis toward helpdesk, reactive support, and administrative processing rather than coordinator-level coordination.
- Reporting into a Support Manager with integrated team working changes who sets priorities, who signs off work, and how independently responsibilities are held.
- ROH described the new role as an amalgamation of three roles. That does not show Christa's coordinator post is an automatic direct match without fuller assessment.

Hybrid working and whether the role is workable

- Christa works part-time (four days), hybrid (two office, two home), with arrangements structured around childcare.

- At the start of consultation, flexible working was said to remain unchanged. Later, office attendance was said to be for the new manager to decide.
- Expectations on office-based working may have been communicated more clearly to others than to Christa, despite management knowing her hybrid pattern and childcare commitments.

Practical concerns and consultation timing

- Helpdesk coverage between 8am and 6pm was raised at consultation, but how that would work for part-time staff remains unclear and was to be discussed with the new manager.
- Workload split, sickness cover, office attendance, and whether staff might be expected outside contracted days were deferred until a new manager is in post (mid to late June).
- Christa could not assess whether the role would work day to day before the voluntary redundancy deadline while these arrangements were still TBC.

Overlap in duties already performed

- Christa recognises overlap in access control coordination, contractor liaison, purchase orders, SharePoint maintenance, and coordination tasks.
- Her concern is how those functions would work in practice: integrated team working, escalation to Manager, and different sign-off, not mere relabelling of duties she already performs.

Consultation quality

- Christa remains concerned that meaningful consultation would allow employees to assess suitability with enough practical detail before being asked to treat the role as a predetermined match.
- Key questions on helpdesk hours, office attendance, workload, and team structure could not be answered at the 18 May meeting and remain open.

Conclusion. The proposed role may contain some familiar duties, but the extent of restructuring means it cannot reasonably be treated as an automatic direct match without fuller assessment. It appears to be a materially changed or merged role. It should therefore be treated as proposed suitable alternative employment, subject to proper consultation, written clarification, objective comparison, and consideration of Christa's circumstances.

Throughout consultation, Christa has continued to engage constructively, raise practical questions, and consider the proposal in good faith. Her concerns relate to how the proposed role would work in practice, rather than resistance to organisational change itself.